the biggest Hollywood spectacles have."

It's a sentiment the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh-backed Bharatiya Chitra Sadhana (BCS) is likely to readily approve. Founded in 2016, the organisation aims to encourage films promoting 'Bharatiya' values and re-establish 'Bharatiya' ethos through cinema. "There are issues related to interpretation of history, dharmic groups, lack of literature on several historical events," says an RSS insider. "We encourage them to pick up issues important to civilisation." A top pracharak of the Vishwa Hindu Parishad notes that while the West equates Hindu culture with "mythology", in 'Bharat', those values are part of "*parampara*" (tradition) or "*dharmic*" lore (stories, philosophy, legends and cultural knowledge). As the genre gains traction and pays dividends, BCS hopes to set a standard for how deities are visually portrayed on screen, while leaving the actual production to the makers.

Some, though, see the spate of mythologicals as concerning. "In early Indian cinema, mythology provided filmmakers established narratives and recognisable characters and also offered a way to negotiate British colonial censorship, indirectly articulate anti-colonial sentiments, and foster pride in India's cultural heritage," says Sanghita Sen, assistant professor in the School of Design, Arts & Creative Industries at Northumbria University, Newcastle. "But we need to distinguish these historical uses from contemporary attempts to present mythology as verifiable history. Today, certain films mobilise mythology to advance Hindutva ideology within a wider political ecosystem, privileging a homogenised, ethnonationalist majoritarian identity over India's fundamentally plural and diverse cultural landscape. The issue is not mythology itself, but its politicisation and deployment as propaganda." Sen cites the Akshay Kumar-starrer *Ram Setu*—about Ram's journey on the mythical bridge between India and Sri Lanka—as one such example.

For audiences, such films help reaffirm their religious beliefs, and also make for family-friendly viewing. According to Dr Harish Shetty, a leading psychiatrist based in Mumbai, the growing tendency to gravitate towards films like *Mahavatar Narsimha*, *Laalo* and *Hanuman Ansh* stems from the innate need for catharsis and hope in a world afflicted by disconnection. "With turmoil across the world, you don't see a saviour. Indians want to see a 'figure' who will save them from their sins and pain," he says. "They are invariably saying, let the eleventh avatar [of Vishnu] come and do something. People are looking for miracles."



"A devotional film need not be a giant spectacle.... Hindi cinema has an unenviable ability to identify an emerging opportunity and eliminate it with oversupply"

Shailesh Kapoor, *Co-founder, Ormax Media*

Making the Divine Dramatic

Devotional cinema is hardly new in Bollywood. It was among the earliest genres to capture filmmakers' imagination when they first turned to the camera, making silent films. From Dadasaheb Phalke's *Raja Harishchandra* (1913), which heralded the birth of Indian cinema, to Prabhat Studios' 1930s and '40s dramas such as *Gopal Krishna*, *Sant Dnyaneshwar* and *Sant Tukaram*, films were a means to disseminate religious values to the masses. This cinematic embrace of *bhakti*—sometimes counted as a distinct *rasa* (emotional essence) akin to the nine described in the *Natyashastra*—endured, reaching a high point in the 1970s with *Jai Santoshi Maa* (JSM) and *Shirdi Ke Sai Baba*. Released in 1975, *Jai Santoshi Maa* gave even the blockbuster *Sholay* a run for its money at the box office. Its titular goddess helped a woman endure a tyrannical *sasural* and even brought her back from the dead.

By the '80s, though, mythological storytelling migrated to television, entering millions of homes through Ramanand Sagar's *Ramayan* and B.R. Chopra's *Mahabharat*. Both became national obsessions, drawing audiences in unprecedented numbers. "The whole country would come virtually to a standstill during the broadcast,"

